

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | THURSDAY, AUGUST 27, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Judge lifts mail voting order hurdle

Democratic officials file new challenges as midterms loom

By Nicholas Riccardi
and Lindsay Whitehurst
ASSOCIATED PRESS

A federal judge Wednesday lifted a major obstacle to President Donald Trump's executive order limiting mail voting, even as Democratic state officials filed a new court challenge with the midterm elections fast approaching.

The fresh round of legal wrangling comes two days after the

Supreme Court handed down a procedural ruling in Trump's favor, and could mean the issue lands before the high court again before the pivotal contests for control of Congress.

The first mailed ballots are set to be sent out next week.

U.S. District Judge Indira Talwani in Boston agreed to lift an order prohibiting the U.S. Postal Service from carrying out Trump's order for November's elections. She

wrote that she was "compelled" to do so after the Supreme Court's conservative majority ruled that a similar injunction she granted in a separate case was premature.

Talwani nevertheless said the executive order could unleash "chaos" and referred to it as "likely unconstitutional."

The administration can now move forward and implement a Postal Service rule published late Friday. It would require states to

follow a uniform envelope style for mail ballots and to give the Postal Service a list of voters eligible to receive them.

A new lawsuit, filed by 25 Democratically controlled states against the U.S. Postal Service, marked a new phase in the high-stakes litigation.

It came after the Supreme Court ruled against them in a separate case, but did not say Trump's order was legal.

The high court majority found the initial Democratic lawsuit was premature, but that was before the

Republican administration issued a rule governing Postal Service delivery of mail ballots.

Election officials warn it will be impossible to implement before the first wave of mail ballots are sent out next week.

"Across the country, states are already deep into preparations for the 2026 elections. Now, at the last moment, the federal government is attempting to meddle in those preparations and potentially threaten countless Americans' right

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Surrounded by supporters outside St. Sabina Church, the Rev. Michael Pfleger, center, celebrates being reinstated on Wednesday after an allegation of sexual abuse dating back to the 1990s was deemed not credible. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

‘The archdiocese’s process is unjust, and it’s broken’

Reinstated St. Sabina pastor challenges the church’s child abuse inquiry procedures

By Allison Kiehl
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The grand concrete steps in front of St. Sabina Church were packed Wednesday morning as parish members crowded to stand with their newly reinstated pastor, the Rev. Michael Pfleger, both physically and spiritually.

A jovial energy enveloped the crowd of around 100 community members, Leo Catholic High School students and St. Sabina staff members, who stood shoulder to shoulder. Many wore custom T-shirts bearing slogans such as “Ain’t no pastor like the one I got” and “Truth will reveal.”

Cheers erupted as Pfleger, the church’s pastor for over 40 years and a community advocate, took to the microphone.

Pfleger spoke at a central podium not only to announce his renewed position at the church in the Auburn Gresham neighborhood, but also to challenge the Archdiocese of Chicago’s process for investigating child sexual misconduct, a system he has encountered multiple times in recent years.

“Brothers and sisters, the archdiocese’s process is unjust, and it’s broken,” Pfleger said. “There is no balance, nor fairness. Without a simple investigation, a

background check or even an interview, a priest can be removed and told to find a place to live and to find a lawyer to represent you at your own expense.”

This came after Pfleger himself was on leave for more than a month while the Archdiocese of Chicago investigated an allegation that he sexually abused a female student at St. Sabina 30 years ago. He was on leave from his South Side parish from July 11 until Monday, when Cardinal Blase J. Cupich reinstated him. The claims were ultimately deemed unfounded. This was the fifth time Pfleger has faced abuse allegations since 2021, with all

previous claims unsubstantiated as well.

Pfleger alleged that the current investigation process in cases of child sexual abuse assumes guilt until the accused person is proved innocent, contrary to United States legal ethics.

“The problem with the process in simple terms is that it’s too quick to accuse and to remove a priest, and too slow to resolve it,” said Pfleger’s lawyer, Jim Figliulo.

The archdiocese’s process of reviewing any misconduct allegations of child sexual abuse is thorough, according to Mayra Flores,

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NIPSCO applies for rate increases

Utility seeks up to \$7.33 a month in hikes as storm restoration continues

By Maya Wilkins
POST-TRIBUNE

Following a devastating Aug. 11 derecho that hit northwest Indiana and left hundreds of thousands of residents without power, the Northern Indiana Public Service Co. filed three electric rate increases with the Indiana Utility Regulatory Commission.

According to commission documents, NIPSCO filed three rate increases either on or after Aug. 11. One was filed Aug. 11, and the remaining two were filed Aug. 14 and 20.

The three rate increases will add up to \$7.33 per month, according to IURC documents and Citizens Action Coalition Program Director Ben Inskeep.

“I think this illustrates a broader problem with Indiana policy and how we regulate our utilities,” Inskeep told the Post-Tribune Tuesday. “The General Assembly has passed law after law over the past two decades that gives our utilities the ability to add these tracker mechanisms or build surcharge mechanisms that allow for these frequent rate changes in between base rate changes.”

Inskeep said the increases are trackers, which “allow the utility to recover expenditures on an ongoing basis by adjusting rates on a quarterly or biannual basis for certain categories of costs,” according to the Citizens Action Coalition’s website. Trackers allow utilities to recover costs, and if they underspend, they pass back a credit to customers.

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INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Sox outfielder on a hitting hot streak

White Sox outfielder Tristan Peters is on a hot stretch at the plate, having hit a home run in four straight games. “He’s been incredible,” Sox starter Anthony Kay said. **Sports**

Himalayan disaster kills at least 160

Massive flash floods in a border area of Nepal and China on Wednesday killed at least 160 people and left hundreds of others missing. **Nation & World, Page B4**

Unaccompanied kids getting deported under DHS policy



State Sen. Cristina Castro speaks about unaccompanied immigrant children being targeted for deportation removal in court during a press conference on Wednesday at the National Immigrant Justice Center in Chicago’s Loop. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Children being denied due process in Chicago court, attorneys allege

By Madeline Buckley
and Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The boy who faced Immigration Court Judge Shawn Abraham needed the microphone lowered before his hearing could begin. His feet didn’t reach the floor.

He is 12 years old.

The lawyer and advocate who sat with him at the respondent’s table told Abraham that he had no caregivers in El Salvador, where Abraham would order him deported moments later.

He was one of more than a dozen unaccompanied minors without legal status who appeared

at Chicago Immigration Court Wednesday for a hearing that was unprecedented until recently. During the proceedings, an immigration judge entered removal orders against some of the children, despite their attempts to seek a long-held legal protection to remain in safety in the United States due to abuse or neglect.

Attorneys, advocates and elected officials said the Trump administration began employing the tactic against unaccompanied children in recent months, violating the rights of the children, many of whom have pending petitions for special immigrant juvenile status. Coupled with a loss of a federal government contract that covered legal services for children who enter the U.S. without

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